primitive conditions other than a hesitant mention of pre-revolutionary wooden houses, scarce merchandise sold at black market prices, and orphaned youths, who he described as ‘flotsam and jetsam of the civil war’.

Despite the many homes and children’s colonies, they slept in the open air and warmed themselves in winter at the public fires in streets and squares. Accelerated industrialisation helped to solve such problems too.

3

In later life, as his importance grew, Honecker painted this period in a predictable light, a time of personal political development. ‘You know, my first public appearance on an international issue was in Moscow,’ he told the Soviet magazine Ogoniok in 1983.

I had to give a speech to the members of the railway union. I still remember crossing Red Square and to the left of the Moskva, this big meeting was taking place. Suddenly someone asked that one of us should address the audience. It was decided that Fritz Molter speaks – I had been given this code name in Moscow. I didn’t know what to say, but somehow, I managed the speech. Many years have passed, but I can remember my speech to this day!

4